

Offshore

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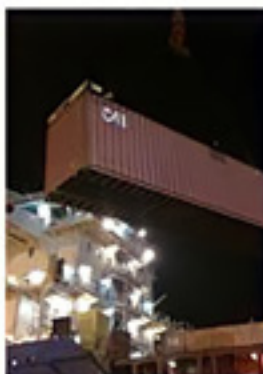
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Africa Reclaims the \$5,000 Gold Moment

As gold edges toward the psychologically potent \$5,000-per-ounce mark, a long-simmering reckoning is taking shape across Africa's gold belt. What was once treated as a windfall largely captured by foreign miners, traders, and offshore refiners is now being re-examined by producer states asking a blunt question: who really benefits when African gold prices soar?

The rally is not accidental. Persistent geopolitical tensions, de-dollarisation pressures, central bank buying, and investor flight from volatile currencies have turned gold into the ultimate hedge. For Africa—home to roughly 40% of the world's gold reserves—the price surge exposes a structural paradox: countries rich in bullion often remain fiscally constrained, while value addition, pricing power, and downstream control sit elsewhere.

This reality is driving sharper policy responses. Ghana, Africa's leading gold producer, has moved decisively to assert greater state control over gold trading. By tightening export rules, centralising gold purchases through state-backed entities, and linking gold flows more directly to macroeconomic stabilisation, Accra is signaling that gold can no longer be merely dug up and shipped out with minimal national gain.

Mali, meanwhile, has taken an even harder line. Amid security pressures and fiscal stress, Bamako has revisited mining contracts, raised royalty expectations, and challenged legacy agreements it views as lopsided. The message is unmistakable: at \$5,000 gold, historical concessions negotiated at \$300 or \$800 no longer pass the political or economic smell test.

Africa's gold producers are no longer content to be price takers. The \$5,000 moment may mark the beginning of a tougher, more assertive era in resource nationalism—one forged not in ideology, but in arithmetic.



GILBERT DA COSTA

Editor-in-Chief,
Offshore Ghana
magazine

NIGERIA – My Life Reporting for CNN

By Gilbert Da Costa

A frontline witness to history, journalist Gilbert Da Costa takes readers on an unforgettable journey through the political storms, violent upheavals, and raw human stories that defined Nigeria in the 1990s and early 2000s. As a correspondent for major international news networks, he reported from the heart of a nation in flux, where ethnic tensions, military rule, and democratic struggles collided in a high-stakes battle for Nigeria's soul.

In this gripping and deeply personal account, Da Costa shares the untold realities of reporting from the frontlines—navigating government censorship, covering volatile elections, and exposing corruption, all while confronting the risks and ethical dilemmas that come with being a journalist in a politically sensitive landscape. Through the lens of his own experiences, he paints a vivid portrait of a country both rich in cultural diversity and fractured by deep-seated divisions, offering rare insights into the forces that continue to shape Nigeria today.

With a compelling mix of reportage and memoir, *Nigeria – My Life Reporting for CNN* is not just a story of journalism under pressure; it is a testament to resilience, the pursuit of truth, and the enduring power of storytelling in the face of adversity.

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Gambia's Offshore Reawakens



• *Cany Jobe, new CEO of Gambia's Petroleum Commission*

After several quiet years, The Gambia's offshore oil and gas sector is stirring back to life, as renewed licensing activity and regional exploration success refocus attention on the West African margin. Long overshadowed by prolific neighbours, the country is once again attracting serious industry interest.

Until early 2024, seven of The Gambia's eight offshore blocks were open after Australia's FAR Ltd relinquished blocks A2 and A5, following unsuccessful Samo-1 and Bambo-1 wells. The final licensed block, A4, was surrendered by PetroNor after it failed to secure a drilling partner, briefly leaving the entire offshore without active licences. That pause proved short-lived.

By late November, blocks A2 and A5 had been re-awarded under 30-year licences to Atlas Oranto, the Nigerian independent led by Arthur Eze, signalling renewed confidence in the basin. Atlas Oranto's recent acreage acquisitions in Liberia reinforce its strategy of targeting underexplored frontier plays across West Africa.

Momentum appears to be accelerating further. At the MSGBC Oil, Gas and Power Conference in Dakar, Gambian officials revealed that ENI and Israel's Ratio Petroleum are close to signing licence agreements. While the specific blocks have not been confirmed, industry speculation points to A1 and A4—areas with compelling geological analogues to Senegal's offshore successes.

These blocks sit along the same trend as Senegal's Sangomar field and the FAN discovery, raising expectations of Albian base-of-slope turbidite fans and contourite reservoirs. At Africa Energy Week in Cape Town, The Gambia's Petroleum Commission highlighted how prospects in block A4 closely mirror those in Senegal. Notably, the Rosewood prospect may even outperform FAN, having experienced less burial—an important factor for reservoir quality.

Block A1 also carries pedigree. Previously held by bp and relinquished in 2021 during the pandemic-era retreat from upstream exploration, it once carried firm drilling commitments, underscoring its perceived potential.

With Atlas Oranto back in play and majors circling, The Gambia's offshore is no longer dormant. Instead, it is emerging as one of West Africa's most closely watched frontier opportunities.

Africa's Offshore Frontier Tests Investor Nerves

Côte d'Ivoire is fast emerging as one of West Africa's most closely watched offshore frontiers, as mixed exploration results sharpen both optimism and caution across the region. Italy's Eni is currently appraising its 2024 Calao gas discovery, widely regarded as a potential anchor resource that could significantly expand the country's domestic gas supply and export ambitions. Just north of Calao, however, Murphy Oil's Civette-1X well on Block CI-502 delivered a more sobering outcome, encountering hydrocarbons that proved non-commercial.

Despite the setback, Murphy argues Civette remains technically encouraging. The well confirmed an active petroleum system, providing valuable subsurface data that will guide two follow-up frontier wells—Caracal and Bubale—targeting prospects that could hold several hundred million barrels of oil

equivalent. Their results will be critical not only for Murphy and state partner PETROCI, but also for shaping investor appetite for Côte d'Ivoire's next licensing rounds, including blocks of interest to Petrobras.

Elsewhere in Africa, frontier momentum is building. In Somalia, Türkiye Petrolleri A.O. is preparing to drill the Curad-1 deepwater well following the country's first offshore 3D seismic survey, a move with potentially transformative implications for East Africa's energy map. In Angola, Shell's renewed farm-ins to Chevron-operated deepwater acreage underline supermajors' continued appetite for large-scale offshore resources.

Together, these developments highlight a broader recalibration: Africa's offshore basins remain high-risk, but selective successes could reshape regional energy balances and capital flows.

Egypt's Western Desert Discoveries Signal Upstream Revival



• *Egypt's Western desert promises new prospects*

Egypt's latest oil and gas discoveries in the Western Desert are reinforcing growing optimism that the country's upstream sector is emerging from a prolonged downturn. Four new exploration wells, expected to deliver nearly 4,500 barrels of oil per day and 2.6 million cubic feet of gas, mark a tangible boost to near-term production at a time when Cairo is under pressure to curb imports and stabilise domestic supply.

The finds, led by Khaldia Petroleum Company—Apache's joint venture with EGPC—alongside Tharwa Petroleum and Borg El Arab Petroleum, highlight the continuing relevance of mature basins when paired with disciplined exploration. Khaldia's Sultan S-1X RC and Alex NW-1X wells alone are producing more than 1,500 bpd of oil and 1.7 MMcf/d of gas, while successful tests by Tharwa and Borg El Arab further underline the Western Desert's residual potential.

Crucially, these results dovetail with Egypt's \$5.7 billion upstream investment programme, which targets 480 exploration wells over five years. After four consecutive years of production decline, national output began edging upward in September, a modest but

symbolically important inflection point for a country that has relied heavily on Israeli gas imports and LNG cargoes since 2022.

Beyond conventional successes, renewed interest in the Abu Roash "F" Formation is reshaping perceptions of the Western Desert. Often likened to the Eagle Ford, the formation is benefiting from horizontal drilling and geosteering techniques deployed by Apache and TAG Oil, unlocking thicker pay zones and naturally fractured reservoirs long considered depleted.

The broader revival is being reinforced by improved fiscal discipline. Egypt has repaid roughly \$5 billion in arrears to international oil companies since mid-2024, restoring confidence after years of delayed payments caused by foreign currency shortages. With arrears set to fall to \$1.2 billion by mid-2026, investment momentum is gradually returning.

Taken together, the Western Desert discoveries, unconventional experimentation, and financial reset suggest Egypt is repositioning itself—not just to arrest decline, but to reassert its role as a regional hydrocarbons hub.

Nigeria's Indigenous Capital Steps Forward as TotalEnergies Recalibrates

TotalEnergies' decision to divest its 10% non-operated stake in the Renaissance joint venture marks another defining moment in the quiet but consequential reshaping of Nigeria's upstream oil and gas sector. Under a newly signed Sale and Purchase Agreement, TotalEnergies EP Nigeria will transfer its participating interests in 15 oil-producing licences to Vaaris Resources, assets that delivered about 16,000 barrels of oil equivalent per day net to the French major in 2025.

The deal also includes TotalEnergies' 10% interest in three gas-producing licences—OML 23, OML 28 and OML 77—but with a crucial twist. While Vaaris will assume the participating interest, TotalEnergies will retain full economic exposure to the gas assets, which currently supply roughly half of Nigeria LNG's feed gas. The structure underscores TotalEnergies' strategic pivot: reducing operational and onshore risk while preserving cash flow tied to globally strategic LNG.

Formerly the Shell Petroleum Development Company JV, the Renaissance venture now reflects a broader industry trend. International majors are steadily retreating from Nigeria's mature onshore and shallow-water assets, citing security challenges, environmental liabilities, community relations and regulatory complexity. Shell, ExxonMobil and Eni have all pursued similar exits, opening space for domestic operators to take control of legacy assets.

Into that space steps Vaaris Resources. Incorporated only in December, the Nigerian special-purpose vehicle has emerged as the preferred buyer after a high-profile 2024 attempt by Mauritius-based Chappal Energies collapsed. That earlier \$860 million deal failed after prolonged financing delays, leaving regulatory fees and environmental obligations unresolved.

Perenco Lifts PNGF Sud Output Past 32,000 bpd

Perenco has delivered a meaningful production uplift at the PNGF Sud field complex offshore Congo, underscoring the value of disciplined infill drilling in mature offshore assets. Five new wells brought on stream late in 2025 have pushed gross exit production for the complex above **32,000 barrels of oil per day**, according to partner PetroNor E&P.

The wells were drilled in the **Tchibouela East** area using the Axima jack-up rig, which completed the campaign in early December. All five infill wells were promptly tied in and placed on production, demonstrating both operational efficiency and strong subsurface understanding. Collectively, the wells delivered a **gross incremental production of more than 6,500 bo/d in December**, a notable uplift for the PNGF Sud portfolio.

PetroNor described reservoir performance as "excellent," reflecting high-quality sands and effective well placement. The results validate Perenco's ongoing strategy of targeted infill drilling to arrest natural decline and extract additional value from existing infrastructure, rather than relying solely on higher-risk exploration.



• Austin Avuru, a Nigerian oil entrepreneur is reportedly a key player in Vaaris

Vaaris is structured as a consortium of six Nigerian companies—three marginal field operators and three oilfield service providers—signaling a deliberate blending of upstream asset ownership with technical execution capability. The group is led by Tein George, a veteran oil and gas executive with deep roots in offshore services, fabrication, engineering and finance.

Industry chatter suggests heavyweight Nigerian capital is circling the transaction, with reports linking figures such as former Seplat CEO Austin Avuru and globally connected financiers. While the full shareholder list remains undisclosed, the message is clear: a new class of indigenous consortia, backed by local expertise and financial muscle, is positioning to inherit assets once dominated by international majors.

If successful, Vaaris would represent more than a transaction—it would signal a maturation of Nigeria's domestic upstream ecosystem, where local players increasingly shape the future of the Niger Delta.

The PNGF Sud complex comprises the **Tchendo II, Tchibouela II, and Tchibeli-Litanzi II** licences, operated by Perenco with a 40% interest. The asset has a diverse partnership base, including PetroNor with an effective 16.83% stake, Congo's national oil company SNPC (15%), Hemla E&P Congo (20%), Continent Congo (10%), Africa Oil & Gas Corp. (10%), and Petro Congo (5%).

For Congo, the production gains reinforce the continued relevance of offshore brownfield investments in sustaining national output and revenues. For Perenco and its partners, the campaign highlights how incremental barrels—when delivered quickly and at low unit cost—can materially improve field economics.

As global capital remains selective and operators increasingly prioritise cash flow resilience, PNGF Sud stands as a pragmatic example of how mature offshore assets, when well managed, can continue to deliver robust production growth well into their later life cycles.

Etame Reaffirms Gabon's Offshore Value



• Gabon's revitalized petroleum sector

Vaalco Energy has delivered a timely boost to Gabon's offshore outlook, confirming a connected and productive reservoir system at the Etame field and reinforcing the asset's role as a steady contributor in a mature basin. Initial estimates of **2.4–3.2 million barrels of oil in place** now underpin the company's next phase of development planning.

The confirmation follows the launch of Vaalco's phase-three drilling programme in the fourth quarter of 2025, beginning with two pilot wells. The first, **ET-15P**, was drilled to a total depth of 2,397 metres in the western Etame-IV fault block, targeting the Gamba formation. The well encountered high-quality reservoir sands consistent with pre-drill expectations, while pressure data confirmed strong communication with nearby producers—clear evidence of a connected reservoir system.

Crucially, ET-15P also evaluated the deeper Dentale formation, encountering good-quality, oil-bearing sands. This result confirmed continuity of the original oil-water contact across this part of the field, materially strengthening confidence in the Etame asset's remaining development potential.

The second pilot well, **ET-15P-ST1**, drilled to 2,175 metres on the western side of the main Etame fault block, further supported the upside case. Targeting the Gamba, the well intersected multiple high-quality sand intervals, delivering approximately nine metres of net reservoir and four metres of net pay across two sand lobes. Detailed volumetric analysis is now under way to assess commercial implications.

Building on these results, Vaalco is currently drilling a horizontal production sidetrack from ET-15P, with first oil expected later in the first quarter. The broader Gabon programme includes multiple development and appraisal wells, workovers, and a re-drill at the Ebouri field to recover reserves previously sidelined by hydrogen sulphide issues.

As operator of the Etame Marin block with a 58.8% interest, Vaalco is demonstrating how disciplined infill drilling and targeted appraisal can continue to unlock value in West Africa's mature offshore provinces.

Africa's Energy Titans Converge in Accra

Accra is set to become the epicentre of Africa's energy and mining conversation as the **4th Africa Energy and Mining Summit & Exhibition** opens on **October 27–28, 2026**, marking the **15th anniversary of Offshore Africa Energy and Mining Magazine**.

Convened by **Jubert Communications Ltd.**, the landmark event will gather senior policymakers, regulators, national and indigenous energy companies, financiers, mining executives, and technology leaders from across Africa and beyond for two high-impact days of conference and exhibition. Held under the theme **“From Resources to Resilience: Powering Africa's Energy and Mineral Future,”** the Summit comes at a defining moment for the continent's energy security, industrialisation drive, and resource governance.

Unlike generic talk-shops, the Accra Summit is deliberately structured as a **solutions-driven, decision-level platform**, focused on moving Africa beyond raw resource extraction toward value-added, resilient energy and mineral systems. Core discussions will centre on gas monetisation, gas-to-power integration, domestic energy security, mining value chains, and the expanding role of **indigenous African operators** in shaping the continent's future.

Over previous editions, the Africa Energy and Mining Summit has earned the confidence of leading institutions and companies, including **GNPC, Ghana's Petroleum Commission, Tullow, Solewani Group, Pecan Energies, Ghana Gas Company, MODEC, GOIL Plc, and Noble Corporation**—cementing its reputation as a serious forum for policy dialogue and investment engagement.

The 2026 edition builds on that legacy



• 2026 Africa Energy & Mining Summit will bring together key stakeholders

with an expanded exhibition floor and a powerful lineup of global and African personalities. Ghana's energy story will feature prominently, from the rebound of the **Jubilee Field**—now producing over 100,000 barrels per day—to renewed momentum around the **TEN gas fields**, the **Voltaian Basin onshore exploration programme**, and the growing importance of gas in stabilising power supply.

“Truth and new ideas have never been more important,” said **Gilbert Da Costa**, Editor-in-Chief of Offshore Africa. “This Summit is where Africa's energy leaders speak frankly—on and off the record—about what works, what doesn't, and what must change.”

Hosted in Accra, a city synonymous with political stability, regulatory reform, and gas-to-power ambition, the Summit promises robust debate, strategic insight, and actionable outcomes. As Offshore Africa marks fifteen years at the forefront of energy journalism, the 4th Africa Energy and Mining Summit positions itself not just as a conference—but as a **defining moment in Africa's energy journey**.

Join the conversation that matters.

Panoro Energy's Africa Outlook For 2026

Panoro Energy enters 2026 with a strong African growth pipeline, building on a record production performance in 2025 and a disciplined financial strategy. The company's focus is on converting mature discoveries and near-field opportunities into incremental production and cash flow, while maintaining balance sheet strength and shareholder returns.

Offshore Gabon is the primary growth engine. The MaBoMo Phase 2 drilling programme at the Dussafu Marin Permit, sanctioned in late 2025, comprises four new production wells with first oil targeted for the second half of 2026. Once fully onstream, gross output is expected to rise toward the facility's nameplate capacity of about 40,000 barrels per day. In parallel, the Bourdon discovery is being matured toward final investment decision, offering additional upside beyond the current development plan.

In Equatorial Guinea, 2026 will focus on restoring full production at the mature Block G assets while advancing higher-value opportunities at Block EG-23. The Estrella discovery has been high-graded as a fast-track development candidate, with tie-back potential to existing infrastructure significantly reducing execution risk.

Tunisia's TPS assets are expected to provide stable base production, supported by workovers and optimisation campaigns. Backed by a healthy cash position of nearly USD 78 million, Panoro is well placed to execute its African growth strategy in 2026 while continuing to reward shareholders.

Namibia Oil & Gas 2026: Shaping Energy's Future

The **4th Namibia Oil and Gas Conference and Exhibition** will take place from **18–21 August 2026 in Windhoek**, promising to be the continent's premier platform for shaping the future of Namibia's oil and gas industry. Building on the success of previous editions, the 2026 event will convene global energy leaders, investors, policymakers, and technical experts to explore strategic opportunities across the entire value chain.

Highlights will include **world-class masterclasses, local content development sessions, and two days of technical and strategic dialogue**, complemented by a dynamic commercial exhibition. The conference aims to foster cross-sector collaboration, advance sustainable energy solutions, and attract investment into Namibia's growing hydrocarbons sector.

Organisers expect the event to surpass previous participation, reinforcing NOGC's role as a global convening hub where ideas, innovations, and partnerships converge to drive the next phase of energy transformation in Namibia and the broader Southern African region.

Bentley Systems Accelerates AI-Driven Infrastructure Analytics

The modern era depends on two invisible but indispensable networks: power grids and cellular systems. Together, they underpin electricity supply, telecommunications, and the digital infrastructure that enables artificial intelligence (AI). Yet maintaining these sprawling systems remains a costly and labor-intensive challenge. Bentley Systems, a global leader in infrastructure engineering software, is addressing this challenge with its **Asset Analytics platform**, which leverages drones, AI, and machine learning (ML) to digitize and monitor transmission and cell towers.

Over the past two years, Bentley's technology has analyzed more than **40,000 towers**, detecting anomalies as subtle as a **1-degree tilt in a transmitter**, saving operators significant maintenance costs and reducing manual inspections across urban and remote sites. The platform transforms high-resolution imagery into **digital twins**, enabling predictive maintenance, real-time monitoring, and asset optimization.

In December 2025, Bentley bolstered its capabilities through the acquisitions of **Talon Aerolytics** and the technology assets of **Pointivo**. Talon's no-code workflows and

AI-powered inspection insights streamline enterprise-wide site surveys and tower digitization across telecom, broadband, and utility networks. Pointivo contributes advanced drone data processing, damage detection, and geolocation, extending Bentley's horizontal analytical capabilities.

These acquisitions strengthen Bentley's Asset Analytics portfolio at a pivotal time, supporting **global 5G deployments, grid modernization**, and expanding demand for infrastructure digitization. By integrating AI across sectors, Bentley enables **continuous inspections**, operational efficiency, and improved maintenance economics. The combined expertise of Talon and Pointivo not only validates Bentley's business model but also accelerates the company's leadership in the emerging asset intelligence market.

As electrification and next-generation network deployments accelerate, Bentley Systems is positioning itself as a **critical enabler of smart infrastructure**, helping operators and owners transform traditional maintenance into **data-driven, predictive, and scalable operations**, underscoring the future of resilient, AI-powered energy and telecom networks.



• The Baleine FPSO

Eni Sells Baleine Stake to SOCAR

Eni has signed a binding agreement with Azerbaijan's state energy firm SOCAR to sell a 10% stake in Côte d'Ivoire's Baleine offshore project, the country's flagship hydrocarbon development. Operated by Eni, alongside Vitol and Petroci, the deal reflects Eni's "dual exploration model," which accelerates value creation through early monetisation of discoveries.

The transaction deepens a broader strategic partnership between Eni and SOCAR spanning hydrocarbons, emissions reduction and biofuels. Discovered in 2021, Baleine is Africa's first net-zero emissions development and already produces over 62,000 barrels of oil daily, with output set to more than double under Phase Three.

Heirs Energies Deepens Nigerian Energy Leadership with Strategic Seplat Stake



• Field engineers at Heirs Energies

Heirs Energies has made a landmark move in Nigeria's oil and gas sector by acquiring the full **20.07% equity stake in Seplat Energy Plc** previously held by Maurel & Prom S.A., purchasing 120.4 million shares at **GBP 3.05 per share** in a deal valued at approximately **US\$500 million**. This acquisition underscores a growing trend of **indigenous firms consolidating ownership of strategic energy assets**, signaling confidence in Nigeria's upstream sector and Africa's broader energy future.

The transaction enhances Heirs Energies' position as a **major integrated energy player**, complementing its existing OML 17 operations in the Niger Delta, which produce over 50,000 barrels of oil per day and 120 million cubic feet of gas daily. By acquiring a significant stake in Seplat, a company with 2P reserves of 1.043 billion barrels of oil equivalent and production exceeding 135 kboepd, Heirs Energies gains access to a diversified and well-governed portfolio, strengthening its upstream footprint and gas supply capabilities.

Strategically, the deal has **sector-wide and policy implications**. It reinforces **African capital mobilisation**, as the acquisition was supported by Afreximbank and the African Finance Corporation, demonstrating the continent's capacity to finance high-value energy transactions without reliance on foreign sponsors. It also aligns with Nigeria's push for **indigenous participation in the energy sector**, potentially inspiring regulatory frameworks that prioritise

domestic operators in future divestments of international oil company assets.

From an operational perspective, the collaboration creates opportunities for **synergies in production optimization, brownfield development, and gas monetisation**, particularly in Nigeria's growing domestic gas market. Heirs Energies' expertise in safely revitalising mature onshore fields complements Seplat's established platform, offering potential improvements in efficiency, environmental compliance, and revenue generation.

Chairman Tony Elumelu framed the acquisition as a "long-term investment in Nigeria's and Africa's energy future," reflecting a broader vision for **industrialization, energy security, and shared prosperity**. Beyond the headline figures, this acquisition exemplifies a shift toward **African-led energy value creation**, positioning Heirs Energies and Seplat as key architects of Nigeria's sustainable energy transition.

ONS 2026: Courage at a Defining Moment for Global Energy

As the global energy system confronts climate urgency, geopolitical tension and persistent energy insecurity, the Offshore Northern Seas (ONS) Conference and Exhibition 2026 arrives at a decisive moment. Set to take place in Stavanger, Norway, ONS 2026 is built around a single, resonant theme: **Courage**—a call for bold leadership and fearless decision-making across the entire energy value chain.

The organisers describe Courage as the capacity to confront hard truths, embrace transformative technologies and make choices that balance energy security, affordability and sustainability. According to ONS President and CEO, **Leif Johan Sevland**, the industry now requires far more than technical fixes. It demands leadership willing to place people, fairness and long-term resilience at the centre of energy strategy, while still meeting rising global demand.

ONS 2026 will translate this theme into action across its **nine conference arenas**, the exhibition halls and the wider **ONS+ programme in downtown Stavanger**, where policy debates, innovation showcases and cross-sector dialogue will converge. The theme's four pillars—explored in depth by

ONS—are designed to shape conversations on decarbonisation, offshore innovation, digitalisation, energy security and the evolving role of oil and gas in a transitioning world.

For African producers and energy stakeholders, ONS 2026 offers a uniquely relevant platform. Africa sits at the crossroads of energy transition and development, facing pressure to decarbonise while expanding access, monetising hydrocarbons responsibly and attracting investment. The Courage agenda speaks directly to these realities, offering lessons from one of the world's most advanced offshore energy ecosystems.

Jubert Communications Ltd. will once again play a bridging role by organising a **delegation of energy, oil and gas executives and officials from Ghana to ONS 2026**. The initiative builds on a long-standing track record: Jubert Communications has facilitated Ghanaian participation at ONS since 2016, including a landmark collaboration with the **Petroleum Commission of Ghana and the Norwegian Embassy in Ghana** for ONS 2018.

The Ghana delegation to ONS 2026 will enable regulators, operators, service companies and investors to engage directly with global industry leaders, explore partnerships, and gain insight into offshore best practices, low-carbon solutions and emerging technologies.

At a time when the energy industry must choose between caution and conviction, **ONS 2026 stands as a global forum for courage—and a strategic opportunity for Africa to shape its place in the next energy era.**



• ONS conference host Leif Johan Sevland

Africa's AI Moment: Power, Gas and the Race to Build Digital Sovereignty

Africa stands at a pivotal juncture in the global artificial intelligence and data centre boom. While digital infrastructure on the continent remains heavily concentrated in South Africa, chronic grid unreliability and rising power density requirements are forcing a strategic rethink. Across Africa, the question shaping the next phase of digital growth is no longer fibre-first, but power-first.

AI is rapidly transforming data centres into critical national infrastructure. Globally, electricity demand from AI workloads is accelerating at a pace that compresses a decade of historical growth into just five years. Large-scale AI training clusters now require tens of megawatts for weeks at a time, while inference workloads—embedded across finance, telecoms, healthcare and logistics—are driving continuous base-load demand. Efficiency gains in chips and cooling offer only partial relief; as compute becomes cheaper, consumption rises, reinforcing structurally strong demand.

This global shift has direct implications for Africa. South Africa remains the continent's dominant data centre hub, benefiting from scale, connectivity and market depth. Yet persistent grid instability, load shedding and water stress are pushing operators to explore LNG-to-power solutions, hybrid gas-renewables systems and on-site generation. These trends are no longer marginal—they are becoming prerequisites for hyperscale investment.

Beyond South Africa, new digital frontiers are emerging. Kenya is leveraging its geothermal base to support power-hungry compute clusters with low-carbon baseload electricity.

Egypt is positioning itself as a strategic digital gateway, combining gas-fired generation, renewables and dense subsea cable landings linking Africa, Europe and the Middle East. Nigeria and Mozambique, meanwhile, are seeking to monetise vast natural gas reserves not only for export, but to underpin regional data centre hubs that anchor domestic digital economies.

Submarine cables such as 2Africa and Equiano are reshaping Africa's connectivity map, but fibre alone is insufficient. Grid constraints, regulatory uncertainty, water scarcity and long permitting timelines continue to limit hyperscale build-out. Globally, data centre demand is increasingly concentrated in a small number of power-stressed clusters, from Dublin—where data centres already consume over a fifth of national electricity—to Northern Virginia, where multi-year interconnection queues have made power availability the decisive siting factor. Africa risks facing similar bottlenecks without proactive planning.

In this environment, gas is emerging as a critical enabler of Africa's AI ambitions. Modern gas turbines offer rapid ramping, firm capacity and system stability—attributes that align closely with the 24/7 reliability requirements of AI-driven data centres. Where grid connections are delayed or unreliable, developers are turning to behind-the-meter gas plants, LNG-to-power projects and hybrid microgrids to secure time-to-market. For hyperscalers, the cost of downtime far outweighs marginal increases in electricity prices.

Renewables will play a growing role—globally

expected to supply around half of data centre electricity by 2030—but their variability clashes with the flat load profile of digital infrastructure. Batteries remain uneconomic for multi-day or seasonal balancing, while nuclear power, including small modular reactors, faces long timelines and unresolved waste challenges. Gas, by contrast, offers speed, flexibility and competitive economics, particularly in gas-rich African markets seeking value-added demand.

Climate risk further strengthens the case for firm power. Heat waves, droughts and extreme weather events are already disrupting grids and renewable output worldwide. As data centres expand into hotter and more humid regions, operators are adopting advanced cooling technologies, but these innovations intensify demand for ultra-reliable electricity. Gas-fired generation provides the stabilising backbone when weather-dependent sources falter.

A global trend is now clear: data centre developers are migrating from traditional connectivity hubs to energy-abundant regions with stranded or underutilised gas. Africa, with its vast gas resources and growing digital demand, is uniquely positioned to benefit—if policy, regulation and infrastructure align.

The AI era presents Africa with a rare opportunity to leapfrog: not merely as a consumer of global digital services, but as a host of sovereign, energy-secured compute infrastructure. Realising that vision will depend on recognising a hard truth of the AI economy: without firm, reliable power—delivered at scale and speed—the data centre revolution will pass Africa by.

Ntorya partners advancing Tanzania natural gas project

The partners developing the Ntorya natural gas field in Tanzania expect to complete and commission the 35-km pipeline connecting it to the 210-MMcfd Madimba gas processing plant in third-quarter 2026.

Christopher E. Smith

The partners developing the Ntorya natural gas field in Tanzania expect to complete and commission the 35-km pipeline connecting it to the 210-MMcfd Madimba gas processing plant in third-quarter 2026. Line pipe for the project has been manufactured and is

scheduled to arrive in Tanzania late January 2026.

Regarding development of the field itself, operator ARA Petroleum Tanzania (APT) says contracting "is well advanced" to bring the Ntorya-2 well (NT-2) into production in line with commissioning the pipeline. The company expects to award the principal contract also in January 2026.

Procurement of a drilling rig and associated services for drilling the Chikumbi-1 well (CH-1) and workover of the Ntorya-1 well (NT-1) also continues. All tenders have been received and APT is currently evaluating the tenders.

All necessary casings, tubulars, and wellheads required for the drilling of CH-1 and workover of NT-1 are on site in Ntorya, partner Aminex PLC said. The contract for civil works in and around the Ntorya development has been awarded to a local construction

company. These works are also scheduled to start next month and include:

- Well-pad preparation for CH-1.
- Well-pad rehabilitation for NT-1 and NT-2.
- Conversion of the original Ntorya-3 well site to the Ntorya gas field base.
- Preparation of the site for upstream production infrastructure and ancillary access roads.

Tanzania Petroleum Development Corp., the project's third partner, in July 2025 awarded China Petroleum Pipeline and China Petroleum Technology & Development Corp. the engineering, procurement, and construction contract for the pipeline.

Ntorya contains 1.8 tcf of gas proven by two wells which each produced 20 MMscfd during testing. Local media report an updated unaudited contingent resource estimate of 3.45 tcf gas initially in place (GIIP), with an internally aggregated block total Pmean unrisked GIIP potential of 16.4 tcf and a risked Pmean GIIP potential of 6.9 tcf.

- *Tanzanian President Samia Hassan is keen to see gas production begin*



ANOH Gas Project Achieves First Gas

Seplat Energy Plc (“Seplat” or the “Company”), a leading Nigerian independent energy company listed on both the Nigerian Exchange Limited and London Stock Exchange, is pleased to announce that the 300 MMscfd ANOH gas project has achieved first gas.

Following completion of the 11km Indorama gas export pipeline and receipt of regulatory approval from the Nigerian Upstream Petroleum Regulatory Commission (NUPRC), on Friday 16th January 2026, ANOH Gas Processing Company (AGPC) commenced gas supply to Indorama, under a firm and interruptible offtake Gas Sales Agreements (GSAs). To enable the flow of gas, the four upstream wells, which had been on standby since November 2025, were brought online.

Since first gas, wet gas production has been stabilizing, delivering 40-52 MMscfd of processed gas directly from the ANOH gas plant to the Indorama Petrochemical Plant. Condensate production has reached 2.0-2.5 kboepd and is expected to increase with gas production as the plant ramps up to design capacity.

In addition, preparations are underway to initiate sales of processed gas to the Nigeria LNG (NLNG) with an offtake agreement structured on an interruptible basis and will support the gas plant to further scale production towards full design capacity of 300MMscfd. Meanwhile, the construction of the OB3 pipeline export route by Nigerian Gas Infrastructure Company (NGIC), originally designated as the primary channel for ANOH gas supply to the domestic market, has resumed and a revised completion date will be communicated in due course.

The ANOH gas plant was developed by AGPC, an incorporated joint venture between Seplat Energy and the NGIC. The integrated plant consists of two 150 MMscfd gas processing units, Liquefied Petroleum Gas (LPG) recovery units, condensate stabilization units, a 16MW power plant and other supporting facilities, and has been built to operate with zero routine flares.

Across the unitised field of OML 53 and OML 21, the ANOH gas plant unlocks an estimated 4.6 Tcf condensate rich gas resource base. Seplat’s working interest 2P reserves in the unitised field, as booked at year end 2024, stood at 0.8 Tcf. Seplat will derive value from two distinct income streams: wet gas sales from OML 53 to the ANOH gas plant, and dividends from its 50% equity ownership in AGPC.

The LPG produced from ANOH, combined with the LPG production at Sapele and the Bonny River Terminal (BRT), will make Seplat a leading supplier of clean cooking fuel to the domestic market. In addition, the ANOH gas plant will process the flared gas from the Ohaji field, enabling Seplat to achieve its onshore End of Routine Flaring programme, a key commercial and sustainability initiative for the company.

The ANOH gas plant has been developed without a single recordable Lost Time Incident (LTI) across 17.5-million-man hours, a testament to the focus of the whole team on safe and secure operations.

Roger Brown, Chief Executive Officer of Seplat Energy, said:

“ANOH is the first of the seven critical gas

• The ANOH Gas facility



development projects identified by Federal Government of Nigeria to commence operations. It is an important strategic project for Seplat, our partner NGIC, and Nigeria as a whole. It has taken a significant amount of commitment and hard work to complete the project in a part of the onshore Niger Delta with limited gas pipeline infrastructure, and we are extremely proud of this achievement. This is our third major gas processing facility onshore and increases our Joint Venture gross gas processing capacity onshore to over 850 MMscfd.

“ANOH will provide material income streams for Seplat, reduce our carbon intensity and contribute significantly to the 2030 production target of 200 kboepd, set at our recent CMD. It will also increase energy access for Nigerians in terms of both power and clean cooking fuel for the local communities, while advancing delivery of our mission to support economic prosperity in Nigeria.”

Mozambique LNG Back on Track

TotalEnergies’ decision to relaunch its Mozambique LNG project marks a pivotal moment for both the company and the country’s long-stalled gas ambitions. Speaking at the project’s relaunch ceremony, CEO Patrick Pouyanné confirmed the \$20 billion development is back on track, with first LNG deliveries targeted for 2029 and a major ramp-up in on-the-ground activity expected in the coming months. The restart follows a near five-year suspension triggered by deadly Islamist insurgent attacks in Cabo Delgado, which froze investment and raised doubts over Mozambique’s investment climate.

The project’s return sends a powerful signal to global investors that security conditions have stabilised sufficiently for capital-intensive energy developments to proceed. It also restores momentum to the Rovuma



• TotalEnergies have new timelines for LNG production in Mozambique

Basin, one of the world’s most promising gas provinces, where delayed projects had created a credibility gap between ambition and execution. TotalEnergies’ renewed commitment, reinforced by pledges of financial assistance to Mozambique following recent floods, strengthens its social licence and underscores the strategic importance of the country within its LNG portfolio.

For Mozambique, the implications extend well beyond one project. The government is targeting a record \$5.88 billion in foreign direct investment in 2026, driven largely by LNG developments. Early indicators are encouraging: FDI more than doubled in the first quarter of 2025, led by gas and mining inflows. Alongside TotalEnergies, Eni’s Coral North LNG project, sanctioned at \$7.2 billion, is scheduled to start production by 2028, while ExxonMobil’s larger Rovuma LNG project remains in the wings.

Collectively, these projects could propel Mozambique to become Africa’s third-largest LNG producer. While security and execution risks remain, the resumption of Mozambique LNG may mark the long-awaited inflection point that converts vast gas reserves into durable investment confidence and long-term economic returns for the state and investors.

Africa's LNG Reckoning as Renewables Turn the Screws

By Gilbert Da Costa

For much of the past decade, liquefied natural gas has been sold to Africa—and by Africa—as the fuel of destiny. Cleaner than coal, scalable, exportable and lucrative, LNG underpinned multibillion-dollar projects from Nigeria to Mozambique, Senegal and Mauritania. But a profound shift is now under way. Solar, wind and battery storage are no longer just nibbling at gas's edges; they are rapidly dismantling the economic case for a massive global LNG build-out—and Africa sits squarely in the blast radius.

Globally, the LNG industry is racing ahead with expansion plans that would lift supply by roughly 50% by 2030, according to the International Energy Agency. Supermajors and national champions alike argue the bet is justified: Europe has doubled its LNG imports since Russia's 2022 invasion of Ukraine, artificial intelligence is fuelling electricity demand through data centres, and policymakers—from Washington to Brussels—still frame gas as the essential “transition fuel.”

Yet even within the industry, unease is growing. TotalEnergies CEO Patrick Pouyanné has warned bluntly that the sector is “building too much.” Others are less diplomatic. At last year's Gastech conference, Gulfstream LNG chief Vivek Chandra described the prevailing mood as “irrational exuberance.” The numbers increasingly support their scepticism.

The core problem is simple and brutal: renewables are winning on cost, speed and scale. Gas turbines have tripled in price since 2021, rising to about \$2,400 per megawatt-hour, while battery costs fell by roughly 40% in 2024 alone. Wood Mackenzie estimates that by 2030, renewable power paired with storage could be as much as 56% cheaper than gas-fired generation. For power utilities—especially in capital-constrained emerging markets—that is not a marginal difference; it is decisive.

Africa feels this shift acutely, both as a producer and a consumer. On the export side, the continent has pinned high hopes on LNG as a route to monetising gas reserves and earning foreign exchange. Nigeria, Africa's largest LNG exporter, is seeking to expand NLNG capacity. Mozambique is struggling to restart its flagship LNG project amid security challenges. Senegal and Mauritania

are preparing to bring their first offshore LNG volumes to market. All assume a hungry global market willing to sign long-term contracts at attractive prices.

But demand signals are deteriorating fast. China—the world's biggest LNG importer and a key target market for African gas—is pivoting aggressively towards renewables. Massive investments in wind, solar and hydropower have pushed LNG imports into year-on-year decline for 11 consecutive months. When Beijing does buy gas, it is increasingly inclined to source cheaper pipeline supplies from Russia rather than higher-cost LNG from the United States, Qatar—or Africa.

Asia more broadly, long viewed as LNG's growth engine, is also slipping out of gas's grasp. Renewable projects can be built in roughly a year, compared with five years or more for gas-fired power plants. Worse still for gas, turbine manufacturers—GE Vernova, Siemens Energy and Mitsubishi Heavy Industries—have warned of delivery backlogs stretching up to eight years. That effectively kills gas's role as a rapid coal replacement in countries like Vietnam and the Philippines. Solar farms and batteries, by contrast, can be deployed almost immediately.

For African gas exporters, this convergence of trends raises uncomfortable questions. If global LNG supply floods the market just as demand growth stalls, prices will weaken and competition will intensify. High-cost, late-to-market projects—often the case in frontier African developments—risk being squeezed out. The spectre of stranded assets looms large, especially for projects that depend on long-term offtake agreements signed at premium prices.

On the import side, the implications are just as profound. Many African governments have promoted gas-to-power as the backbone of industrialisation and energy security. But falling renewable and battery costs are rewriting that script. Countries such as Kenya, Morocco, Egypt and South Africa are already demonstrating that large-scale solar and wind, backed by storage, can stabilise

• An LNG facility in Mozambique. Questions are being raised about the long-term viability of gas as a transition fuel



grids and reduce reliance on imported fuels. For energy-poor nations struggling with dollar shortages, renewables offer insulation from volatile global gas markets.

This is where LNG's “transition fuel” narrative begins to fray. Transition fuels are meant to bridge old and new systems—not crowd them out. Yet today, LNG risks being leapfrogged altogether in many African power markets. Why lock into expensive, imported gas infrastructure when solar, wind and batteries are cheaper, faster and increasingly reliable?

None of this means gas disappears overnight. Africa still needs flexible generation to balance grids, support industrial loads and backstop intermittent renewables. Domestic gas can play that role where infrastructure already exists. But the era of gas as the unquestioned growth story—especially LNG destined for distant markets—is ending faster than many project developers anticipated.

For policymakers and investors across Africa, the lesson is stark. Betting national development strategies on a prolonged global LNG boom is becoming a high-risk gamble. The smart pivot is towards diversification: using gas selectively at home, accelerating renewables deployment, and avoiding overexposure to export projects that may arrive just as the market turns.

The LNG industry once thrived on the assumption that energy transitions move slowly. Solar panels, wind turbines and lithium batteries are proving otherwise. For Africa's LNG ambitions, the squeeze is on—and the pressure is only just beginning.

Aging Platforms Drive Angola's Methane Emissions

Angola's offshore methane challenge is driven less by oil output than by the age of its infrastructure. New airborne measurements from the METHANE-To-Go Africa (MTGA) campaign reveal a sharp divide between legacy shallow-water platforms and modern deepwater facilities.

Platforms commissioned before 2000—mostly fixed installations near the coast—emit around ten times more methane than post-2000 deep and ultra-deepwater floating production, storage and offloading units (FPSOs). These emissions are largely caused by unmonitored leaks and venting rather than

flaring, and in many cases were unknown to operators.

Aircraft data also show that conventional bottom-up inventories and operator reports significantly misrepresent actual emissions. Methane from aging shallow-water platforms is systematically underestimated, while emissions from newer FPSOs—often connected to Angola LNG and fitted with advanced controls—are frequently overstated. The study found that production volumes are a poor proxy for methane intensity; infrastructure age, design, maintenance practices and gas-export connectivity are far

more influential.

The MTGA campaign detected intermittent but severe methane releases, some exceeding 10 tonnes per hour, persisting for days and spreading tens of kilometres offshore. Satellites captured only the largest plumes, underscoring the importance of airborne monitoring.

Overall, the findings point to targeted monitoring and mitigation of legacy assets as the most effective path to reducing Angola's offshore methane emissions.



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Libya's Oil Reckoning: America Returns, Ambition Rises

By Our Reporter

Libya's long-dormant oil superpower ambitions are stirring again, propelled by an unmistakable shift in Western—and especially American—engagement. After more than a decade of civil conflict, fractured governance, and investor paralysis, the country is witnessing a convergence of capital, diplomacy, and security cooperation that could redefine its place in the global energy order.

At the centre of this resurgence is the United States.

Speaking at the Libya Energy and Economy Summit in Tripoli, Massad Boulos, senior adviser to US President Donald Trump on Arab World and Middle East affairs, delivered a message that resonated well beyond the conference hall: Washington expects Libya's oil production to rise to **three million barrels per day**, and US companies are prepared to help make it happen.

"This is not an ordinary conference," Boulos told delegates. "It is a turning point... a bright return for Libya to the ranks of the world's major energy powers."

For a country whose production has repeatedly surged and collapsed since the overthrow of Muammar Gaddafi in 2011, the statement marked a decisive rhetorical shift—from crisis management to scale, ambition, and strategic alignment.

The American Signal

The renewed American push into Libya's energy sector carries geopolitical weight. US–Libya relations have historically been turbulent, shaped by sanctions during the Gaddafi era, US air strikes in the 1980s, and the 2012 Benghazi attack that killed the US ambassador. For years, American companies approached Libya cautiously, if at all.

That caution is now fading.

Boulos framed his participation as a direct message from President Trump affirming Washington's readiness to work with Libya across energy, security, and economic development. He stressed that US engagement is being intensified "across all regions of Libya," an important signal in a country still divided between a UN-backed government in Tripoli and an eastern administration aligned with Field Marshal Khalifa Haftar.

Security, Boulos argued, is inseparable from oil investment. His praise for Libya's hosting of the **Flintlock 2026 military exercises**, involving eastern and western forces alongside US partners, underscored Washington's belief that stabilising Libya's energy sector requires parallel progress on military cooperation and national cohesion.

"Revitalising this industry isn't just about geology," he said. "It's about stability."

A Landmark Deal at Waha

The strongest proof that Libya's investment climate is shifting came with the signing of a **25-year oil development agreement** between Waha Oil Company, France's TotalEnergies, and US-based ConocoPhillips.



• Massad Boulos, President Trump's Special Envoy to Africa, supports Libya's oil production to 3 million barrels

Valued at more than **\$20 billion**, the deal is one of the largest foreign-financed investments in Libya's oil sector since 2011.

Structured through Waha—a subsidiary of the National Oil Corporation (NOC)—the agreement aims to increase production capacity by up to **850,000 barrels per day**, a transformative jump for a company currently producing between 340,000 and 400,000 bpd under normal conditions. Prime Minister Abdulhamid al-Dbeibah projected **net revenues exceeding \$376 billion** over the life of the deal.

For ConocoPhillips, which holds a 20.4% stake in Waha alongside TotalEnergies, the agreement represents both continuity and recalibration. The US major has operated in Libya since 1955, withdrew during the sanctions era, returned in 2005, and remained present even as civil war drove others away.

"In the last two years, we have been in renegotiations with the Libyan authorities," said Glenn Hamrell, executive vice president at Waha. "We reached an agreement that improves fiscal terms and allows us to invest more for long-term growth."

The message is implicit but clear: Libya needs external capital to unlock its resources, and foreign companies need more competitive terms to justify long-term exposure.

Chevron's Return and a US Surge

Beyond Waha, American interest is accelerating. Chevron has signed an initial agreement to return to Libya after a **15-year absence**, while Halliburton and SLB are expanding operations, betting that Libya will become one of the fastest-growing energy markets in the region.

"2026 is going to be a turning point for Halliburton," said Chris Simonian, the company's Libya business development manager. "We see the biggest growth opportunity in Libya today."

SLB echoed that optimism, citing improved certainty on payments and rising activity levels. For oilfield service companies—often the first to feel political and operational risk—the shift is a critical signal of confidence.

Libya's **first oil exploration bidding round in more than 17 years**, with results expected in February, has further reinforced momentum. US majors including Chevron and ExxonMobil have qualified for

the final round, while Oil Minister Khalifa Abdulsadiq has indicated that a **second licensing round is almost certain**, buoyed by unexpectedly strong international interest.

The Three-Million-Barrel Question

Libya is already one of Africa's largest oil producers and a member of OPEC. Reaching **three million bpd** would place it firmly among the world's top-tier producers, potentially rivaling Nigeria as Africa's leading oil power.

Yet the scale of the challenge is formidable. Years of underinvestment have degraded infrastructure, while pipeline sabotage, militia disputes, and political fragmentation have repeatedly disrupted output. The NOC has announced **\$2 billion in pipeline and infrastructure upgrades**, and Eni is advancing gas projects aimed at eliminating flaring and boosting exports to Europe, but sustained progress depends on political stability.

Legal Fault Lines and Political Risk

The recent wave of long-term agreements has also reopened contentious debates over the **rules governing foreign partnerships**. A previous amendment to NOC's agreement with Eni—granting the company a larger stake in exchange for joint investment commitments—set a precedent that other international firms are now seeking to replicate.

While influential political actors in eastern Libya have largely refrained from public objections, the judiciary has stepped in. Libya's Public Prosecutor has opened investigations into amendments to production-sharing agreements and summoned former NOC chairman Farhat Ben Qaddara for questioning.

Former Oil Minister Mohamed Aoun has publicly argued that the Waha agreement violates existing legislation and parliamentary decisions restricting new contracts. The dispute highlights a deeper structural issue: how to reconcile urgent investment needs with unresolved questions of authority in a divided state.

A Narrow Window

Oil and gas account for **95% of Libya's exports and government revenue**, making the sector indispensable to economic recovery. Recent expansion helped push GDP growth above 13%, according to the World Bank, underscoring what is at stake.

What is unfolding now is a narrow and consequential window—marked by American political backing, renewed Western investment, and cautious improvements in security cooperation. Whether Libya can convert this convergence into durable stability remains uncertain.

For now, the signal is unmistakable: the United States is back, capital is flowing, and Libya's oil future—long constrained by conflict—is once again being written at scale.

GOIL Soars as Shares Surge, Fuel Falls

GOIL PLC has emerged as one of the most compelling success stories on the Ghana Stock Exchange in 2025, delivering a rare combination of **strong shareholder returns and direct consumer relief** at the pumps—an alignment that has reignited investor confidence and strengthened its national brand.

Against the backdrop of one of the GSE's strongest rallies in recent years, GOIL's performance stood out. Improved macroeconomic stability, easing inflation, and a decisive investor shift away from fixed-income instruments toward equities created fertile ground for market gains. Within this environment, GOIL's share price **nearly doubled**, climbing from **GH¢1.52 at the start of 2025 to GH¢2.96 by year-end**, a remarkable **95% increase**. The rally marked a sharp turnaround from 2024's largely flat performance and signalled renewed market conviction in the company's trajectory.

Investors have responded positively to GOIL's renewed strategic focus under the leadership of **Group CEO and Managing Director, Edward Abambire Bawa**. Since assuming office, management has prioritised **strong governance, operational efficiency, financial discipline, and accountability**—fundamentals that have translated into credibility with the investing public and reinforced GOIL's status as Ghana's leading fully indigenous downstream petroleum company.

Yet GOIL's 2025 story extends well beyond capital markets. In a move with immediate real-world impact, the company implemented a **targeted fuel price reduction at 150 outlets nationwide**, its second price cut this month, explicitly aimed at easing the cost of living. Petrol prices were reduced to



GH¢9.99 per litre, down from GH¢10.99—the **first return to single-digit petrol prices in nearly a decade**. Diesel prices also fell to **GH¢11.21 per litre**, from GH¢11.96, at selected stations.

According to Mr Bawa, the intervention focuses on GOIL stations located near **commercial transport terminals and major logistics corridors**, serving public transport operators and vehicles that move food and goods from farms to markets. The objective is clear: ensure that Ghana's improving macroeconomic conditions translate into **lower transport costs, moderated food prices, and tangible relief for ordinary Ghanaians**.

The initiative reflects GOIL's dual identity as

both a competitive commercial enterprise and a **national energy company with socio-economic responsibilities**, particularly during periods of economic recovery. Management attributes the pricing flexibility to improving fundamentals, including macroeconomic stability, easing inflation, and renewed confidence—developments it links to the government's economic stewardship.

As GOIL consolidates its financial gains while deepening its social impact, the company is positioning itself as a rare example of how **market success and public value can reinforce each other**. For shareholders and consumers alike, 2025 has marked a decisive turning point—one that underscores GOIL's promise of delivering "good energy" to power Ghana's growth.

Fuel Relief Ahead as Rand Roars Back

South African motorists are heading into February with rare good news at the pumps. Fresh data from the Central Energy Fund (CEF) points to **sizeable fuel price cuts** across petrol, diesel, and illuminating paraffin—offering tangible relief after months of volatility.

By the end of the third week of January, petrol prices were showing **over-recoveries of 66–69 cents per litre**, while diesel posted similar gains of **63–71 cents per litre**. Illuminating paraffin is also poised for a **60-cent drop**. Although recoveries have softened slightly since mid-month, they remain firmly positive—driven by a supportive exchange rate and still-manageable global oil prices.

The global backdrop, however, remains anything but calm. Oil prices climbed this week to above **\$65 a barrel**, buoyed by a weaker dollar and renewed risk appetite after geopolitical tensions between the United States and the European Union eased. Markets had been rattled by US President Donald Trump's aggressive rhetoric on Greenland and threats of punitive tariffs on the EU, raising fears of a renewed global trade war. That anxiety subsided following conciliatory signals at the World Economic Forum in Davos, triggering a risk-on rally that lifted oil prices but softened the dollar.

Even so, oil remains capped by longer-term

fundamentals. The International Energy Agency continues to warn of a **looming supply glut**, with production expected to outpace demand well into 2026—keeping a structural lid on crude prices despite short-term spikes.

The real star of the current fuel price equation is the **rand**, which has staged an impressive comeback. Breaking through the stubborn R16.30/\$ resistance, the currency touched **R16.09/\$**, its strongest level in more than three years, before stabilising near R16.15. The rand's strength reflects both global and domestic tailwinds: fading US fiscal credibility fears, a more dovish Federal Reserve outlook, and South Africa's improving fundamentals.

Domestically, confidence has been boosted by South Africa's **removal from the FATF grey list**, a credible medium-term budget, and its **first sovereign ratings upgrade in two decades**. Growth expectations are also improving, with forecasts rising to **1.3% in 2025 and potentially 3% by 2030**.

Even now, purchasing-power metrics suggest the rand remains undervalued—implying further upside if reforms hold. For motorists, that currency strength may prove just as important as oil prices, translating macroeconomic momentum into real-world savings at the pump.

West Africa Buys More Indian Diesel

West Africa is importing increasing volumes of diesel from India as European Union sanctions on fuel derived from Russian crude trigger a major reordering of global oil flows. Shipping data from Kpler and Vortexa show that India has redirected record diesel volumes to West Africa after halting exports to the EU this month.

The shift follows the EU's ban on fuels produced from Russian crude, introduced to tighten pressure on Moscow over its 2022 invasion of Ukraine. India, which relied on Russian crude for about 30% of its seaborne imports in 2025, had been the EU's third-largest diesel supplier, exporting an average of 137,000 barrels per day (bpd). In January, however, no Indian diesel cargoes were sent to the bloc.

Instead, Indian diesel exports to West Africa surged, reaching an all-time high of about 155,000 bpd in December, with January flows on track for 84,000 bpd. Analysts say the trend is likely to continue as India seeks alternative markets. "The most likely reshuffle is more Indian diesel going into Africa, freeing Middle Eastern supply for Europe," said Clare Morris of Energy Aspects.

Solewant Group Taking Nigerian Content Global

By Our reporter

In a global energy industry increasingly defined by supply-chain resilience, technological sophistication and local capacity, few African companies have projected Nigeria's industrial ambitions as visibly and credibly as Solewant Group. In 2025, the company's strong footprint across major international oil, gas and maritime fora—from Houston and New York to Algiers and London—cemented its status as a flagship indigenous enterprise advancing Nigerian Content Development while competing confidently on the world stage.

Founded 25 years ago, Solewant Group has evolved from a local service provider into a leading African industrial solutions company delivering high-impact projects for international oil companies (IOCs) and engineering, procurement and construction (EPC) firms. Its core strengths—steel pipe manufacturing, advanced multi-layer pipeline coating, anti-corrosion systems, fabrication and field joint protection—place it at the heart of energy infrastructure development, where quality, scale and delivery timelines are non-negotiable.

That credibility is anchored in assets. The company's industrial park in Alode, Eleme Local Government Area of Rivers State spans 156,000 square metres and is widely recognised as Africa's largest pipe-coating facility. In July 2025, Solewant raised the bar further with the commissioning of an ultra-modern Pipe Bend Multi-Layer Pipe Coating Plant. The facility is more than a manufacturing milestone; it is a strategic intervention aligned with Nigeria's ambition to become a continental hub for steel pipe production, reducing import dependence while retaining value within the local economy.

This blend of industrial depth and national relevance framed Solewant's international engagements throughout the year. At the Offshore Technology Conference (OTC) 2025 in Houston—arguably the world's most influential energy technology gathering—the company emerged as a symbol of Nigerian industrial capability. Exhibiting at the Nigerian Pavilion, Solewant showcased home-grown innovations before a high-powered audience that included Nigeria's Ministers of State for Petroleum (Oil and Gas), the Group CEO of NNPC Limited, National Assembly members, IOC executives, and leaders of industry associations such as PETAN and OGTAN.

Representing Group Chief Executive Officer and Founder, Mr. Solomon Ewanehi, Group Executive Director Mr. Matthew Aganren used the platform to signal a strategic inflection point. After 25 years of excelling in steel pipes, fabrication and specialty coating solutions, Solewant, he said, was entering a new phase defined by expanded investments, deeper technology integration and broader continental reach. The message resonated: Nigerian content, when underpinned by scale and competence, is not a protectionist slogan but a competitive proposition.

That proposition drew even wider attention at the 4th Intra-African Trade Fair (IATF

2025) in Algiers, organised by Afreximbank. With 35,000 participants, 2,000 exhibitors and a record \$48.2 billion in trade and investment deals, the fair underscored Africa's accelerating intra-continental commerce. Solewant stood out as one of the leading exhibitors, presenting a robust portfolio of subsidiaries and cutting-edge pipeline technologies that address Africa's infrastructure deficit.

High-profile visits to the company's booth—from former Nigerian President Chief Olusegun Obasanjo to Nigeria's Minister of Industry, Trade and Investment, Dr. Jumoke Oduwale—sparked pointed discussions about value addition. Responding to questions on technology transfer, training and industrial capacity, Ewanehi articulated a philosophy that has become central to Solewant's identity. "Our commitment is not only to deliver world-class coated pipes, fabrication, and specialty protective solutions but also to deepen indigenous capacity through training and technology transfer," he said. "We see Solewant as a vehicle for Africa's self-reliance in energy and infrastructure."

The company's advocacy extended beyond trade and technology into geopolitics and security. On the sidelines of the 80th United Nations General Assembly in New York, Solewant participated in a high-level roundtable on unlocking energy, mineral and maritime opportunities in the Gulf of Guinea—a region with over \$800 billion in energy and infrastructure potential but persistent security challenges. Convened by The New Diplomat in collaboration with the Gulf of Guinea Commission, the forum positioned indigenous industry as a stabilising force.

In his goodwill message, Ewanehi framed Solewant's journey as proof that African firms can anchor development if policy, security and financing align. Over two and a half decades, he noted, the company has invested deliberately in people, plants and products, validating that local enterprises can meet global standards while strengthening job creation and supply-chain resilience. That contribution earned him formal recognition later in the year for outstanding contributions to peace and sustainable development in the Gulf of Guinea.

Europe provided another proving ground. At the Nigerian Upstream Petroleum Regulatory Commission's Roadshow in Dorchester, London—tagged "Project 1MMBOPD: Additional Production Investment Forum"—Solewant joined global industry leaders, regulators and investors to examine Nigeria's ambition to add one million barrels per day through innovation and collaboration. Ewanehi emphasised transparency, emerging technologies and partnerships as essential



• Mr. Solomon Ewanehi, GMD/CEO of fast-rising Solewant Group

drivers for Africa's energy growth, while noting that investor confidence ultimately hinges on robust legal and regulatory frameworks.

Crucially, Solewant's global push did not come at the expense of domestic engagement. The company remained a prominent participant at the Nigerian Oil and Gas Opportunity Fair (NOGOF) 2025 in Yenagoa and hosted its 9th Annual Energy Summit at its Alode-Onne Industrial Park. The summit, themed "Emerging Technologies and the Future of Sustainable Energy Development in Africa," examined how artificial intelligence, robotics, automation and data analytics are reshaping the continent's energy trajectory—signalling Solewant's intent to stay ahead of technological curves.

Looking ahead, the company's ambitions are unapologetically expansive. Ewanehi's "Roadmap Plus," a 10-year industrial development blueprint, targets breakthroughs across oil, gas, energy and water infrastructure in Africa. With plans to mobilise development finance capital for pipeline projects across the continent, Solewant aims to absorb investment, create jobs and build durable local value chains—translating policy rhetoric on local content into measurable industrial outcomes.

Industry recognition has followed. From multiple "Best Oil and Gas Contractor" awards to honours from the Nigerian Content Development and Monitoring Board, Offshore Africa Oil & Gas Magazine and even the House of Lords in London, Solewant's accolades reflect sustained operational excellence rather than episodic success.

In an era when energy security, decarbonisation and localisation are converging, Solewant Group's 2025 journey offers a compelling case study. It demonstrates how an indigenous African company, grounded in manufacturing and driven by technology, can advance national objectives while earning global relevance. For Nigeria—and Africa more broadly—the message is clear: local content, when executed at scale and quality, is not just viable. It is indispensable.

NamibiaOilAndGas.com leverages Data Sovereignty in Africa's Newest Energy Hub

By Cobus Theyse, Co-Founder, Namibia Oil and Gas

As Namibia stands on the precipice of a generational economic transformation, the global spotlight has intensified on the Orange Basin. With world-class discoveries like Venus, Graff, and Mopane, the nation is no longer just a frontier; it is the “New Energy Frontier” of Africa. However, as international supermajors and global investors descend on Windhoek and Lüderitz, a critical question has emerged: Who owns the narrative and the data of this burgeoning industry?

Answering this question led to the creation of NamibiaOilAndGas.com, a homegrown startup that is rapidly becoming the digital backbone of the sector. Initially, a news site it has evolved into a strategic resource hub and guardian of Namibian Intellectual Property (IP). By centralizing data and creating a robust local database, this startup is ensuring that the “information goldmine” of Namibia’s resources stays in Namibian hands, rather than being owned and mined by international organisations. Something that Namibians and Namibia should be very proud of.

A Hub for Local Content and Global Capital

For years, African energy data was the domain of high-priced international consultancies. For a local entrepreneur or a global investor looking for a reliable partner, the barriers to entry were often opaque. NamibiaOilAndGas.com is disrupting the status quo and is launching a comprehensive supplier and human capital database.

This directory is a two-way street welcoming all levels of stakeholders involved in or wanting to contribute meaningfully to the energy sector. For international stakeholders, it provides a transparent, vetted gateway to local capabilities, from logistics and engineering to specialized oilfield services. For Namibian professionals and SMEs, it provides visibility and a platform in a fast-

moving market. By digitizing the regional supply chain and human capital available, the platform ensures that “local content” is not just a regulatory checkbox but a functional reality.

Protecting Data Sovereignty

The startup’s most radical “game-changing” move, however, is its focus on Data Sovereignty. In an era where data is as valuable as oil itself, the platform champions the philosophy that Namibians should manage Namibian data.

By building a local repository of industry insights, regulatory updates, and corporate partnerships, NamibiaOilAndGas.com prevents the “data drain” where vital industry intelligence is often inaccessible behind paywalls or in expensive reports from outside organizations. The startup ensures the nation retains the intellectual leverage needed to negotiate and collaborate with international partners from a position of strength.

Organic Growth in Step with the Sector

The beauty of the resource platform’s model lies in its scalability. Unlike many tech startups that burn through capital in search of a “pivot,” this platform is designed to grow organically and scale alongside the industry’s lifecycle. As the sector moves from exploration to appraisal, the data requirements will shift. This synchronized growth ensures that as the Namibian economy scales, its primary information hub is already embedded in the fabric of the industry.

A Vital Asset for Stakeholders and Investors

For African and international stakeholders, NamibiaOilAndGas.com offers something rare: contextual intelligence. While international news wires may report on



• Cobus Theyse, Co-Founder, Namibia Oil & Gas

a discovery, this platform reports on the implications for the local economy. As well as the regulatory shifts of the government in Namibia, and the training opportunities available to the youth. Local insights and knowledge are an exceedingly powerful tool to have access to. Investors looking to navigate Namibia need more than just geological maps; they need a roadmap of the local ecosystem. The platform provides exactly that, offering a centralized news hub that promotes transparency and fosters collaboration.

The Path Ahead

The success of Namibia’s oil and gas sector will not be measured by barrels per day, but by the strength of the institutions and platforms that support it. By reclaiming the industry’s digital narrative and securing Namibian IP, NamibiaOilAndGas.com is doing more than just providing information; it is building a foundation of trust and resilience.

The most valuable resource isn’t just what lies beneath the seabed; it’s the knowledge, data, and IP that stays within the country’s borders.

For those looking to be part of Namibia’s success story, the journey begins at the intersection of energy and information. For the Namibian people, it starts with owning the data that will power their future.

GNPC, Petrobras Target Voltaian Basin Exploration



• GNPC CEO Kwame Ntamo Amoah with Petrobras officials

Ghana’s long-marginalized onshore Voltaian Basin has returned to the strategic spotlight as the Ghana National Petroleum Corporation (GNPC) deepens technical engagement with Brazil’s national oil company, Petrobras. A weeklong high-level collaboration in Accra in January 2026 underscores GNPC’s intent to reposition frontier onshore exploration as a credible pillar of the country’s upstream

future.

The engagement builds on historic ties dating back to GNPC’s establishment in 1983, when Petrobras supported institutional planning and capacity development. Today’s cooperation is more targeted and operationally focused, anchored by a newly signed Confidentiality Agreement that enables structured data sharing and joint technical analysis. This framework is critical as GNPC seeks to translate frontier geological promise into actionable exploration strategies.

Central to discussions is the Voltaian Basin, a vast intracratonic basin covering nearly 40% of Ghana’s landmass but historically underexplored due to geological complexity, limited subsurface data, and high exploration risk. GNPC views the basin as a long-term strategic option capable of diversifying Ghana’s hydrocarbon portfolio beyond offshore production, which is currently facing natural decline.

Petrobras’ relevance lies in its global reputation for mastering technically

challenging basins, from Brazil’s pre-salt to complex frontier plays elsewhere. GNPC officials see direct applicability in Petrobras’ experience with seismic interpretation, basin modeling, and risk calibration—capabilities essential for unlocking Voltaian Basin prospectivity. The emphasis is not on near-term drilling, but on disciplined subsurface understanding, data integration, and phased exploration design.

The collaboration also aligns with GNPC’s broader ambition to strengthen its internal operatorship and technical self-reliance. By engaging peer national oil companies rather than purely commercial partners, GNPC is prioritizing knowledge transfer and long-term institutional value over short-term exploration bets.

If successful, the GNPC–Petrobras engagement could lay the groundwork for a methodical, data-driven approach to onshore exploration—one that gradually transforms the Voltaian Basin from geological curiosity into a strategic energy option for the future.

• GNPC CEO Kwame Ntow Amoah with Petrobras officials

Nigeria's Power Paradox: Subsidies, Debt, and a Broken Market

Nigeria's electricity sector is trapped in a deepening paradox: despite repeated tariff reforms and bold policy pronouncements, the cost of keeping the lights on for consumers is bleeding the state dry while failing to fix the system's core dysfunctions. New data from the Nigerian Electricity Regulatory Commission (NERC) lays bare the scale of the challenge. Between October 2024 and September 2025, the Federal Government incurred a staggering **₦1.98 trillion in electricity subsidy obligations**, even as it struggles to settle more than **₦4 trillion owed to power generation companies (GenCos)**.

This figure alone underscores the unsustainability of Nigeria's current electricity market structure. Subsidies of **₦471.69bn** in Q4 2024, **₦536.4bn** in Q1 2025, **₦514.35bn** in Q2, and **₦458.75bn** in Q3 show only marginal relief quarter-on-quarter. While the Q3 subsidy declined slightly, it still accounted for **58.63% of total generation invoices**, meaning government effectively paid more than half the cost of power produced in the country.

At the heart of the problem is Nigeria's failure to fully transition to **cost-reflective tariffs**. In the absence of tariffs that reflect real generation and delivery costs, the Federal Government continues to plug the gap between allowed tariffs and actual costs through subsidies. Even the highly publicised **Band A tariff adjustment of April 2024**, which removed subsidies for customers receiving a minimum of 20 hours of electricity supply daily, has failed to materially reduce the fiscal burden.

To contain systemic risk, NERC introduced the **DisCo Remittance Obligation (DRO) framework** in January 2024, replacing the Minimum Remittance Obligation regime. Under the DRO system, distribution companies (DisCos) pay only what their allowed tariffs can cover, while the Federal Ministry of Finance directly settles the subsidy portion with the Nigerian Bulk Electricity Trading Plc (NBET). The shift was meant to prevent unpaid subsidies from crippling DisCo balance sheets and choking off investment.

On paper, remittance performance has improved. In Q3 2025, DisCos remitted **95.23%** of their DRO-adjusted invoices to NBET, while payments to the Market Operator stood at **95.13%**. Most DisCos met their obligations fully, with chronic underperformance limited mainly to Jos and Kaduna DisCos. Yet these headline figures

mask a deeper structural rot.

Despite modest gains in billing and collection efficiency, DisCos recorded **₦315.17bn in billing losses** between Q2 and Q3 2025 alone. Energy theft, poor metering, weak commercial controls, and the inability to bill at allowed tariffs continue to drain revenue. In Q3, DisCos billed only **82.69% of energy offtake** and collected just **80.70% of what was billed**. Aggregate technical, commercial, and collection (ATC&C) losses averaged **33.27%**, far above the MYTO target of 20.54%. Kaduna DisCo's ATC&C loss of **71.10%** starkly illustrates the depth of inefficiency still tolerated in the system.

The fiscal consequences are severe. Without government intervention, total generation costs in Q3 would have reached **₦782.45bn**. Subsidies slashed DisCos' NBET invoice to **₦323.70bn**, shifting the burden squarely onto public finances. Meanwhile, international bilateral customers remitted just **38.09%** of invoices, adding a foreign-currency dimension to liquidity risks.

Industry experts argue that the current subsidy regime is politically convenient but economically ruinous. Power sector advocate **Adetayo Adegbenle** describes electricity subsidies as "not sustainable," warning that unpaid obligations ripple through the entire value chain and deter investment. He and others point to the long-delayed **Power Consumer Assistance Fund**, provided for in the Electricity Act, as a more targeted mechanism to protect vulnerable consumers without distorting the entire market.

Consumer groups are even more scathing. The Nigeria Electricity Consumers Advocacy Network (NECAN) has labelled the service-based tariff model a failure, arguing that subsidies have not fallen and that DisCos are effectively "selling darkness" while collecting revenue. With industrial demand weak and manufacturers reluctant to abandon self-generation, the cross-subsidy logic underpinning Band A tariffs has collapsed.

Nigeria's electricity crisis is no longer just a technical or regulatory issue—it is a macroeconomic risk. Subsidies approaching **₦2 trillion** a year crowd out spending on health, education, and infrastructure, while chronic inefficiencies discourage private capital. Until tariffs, losses, enforcement, and social protection are addressed in a coherent, data-driven manner, Nigeria will remain stuck in an expensive equilibrium: paying more each year for a power sector that delivers too little.

Data Centres: Africa's Unlikely Power Fix



• N.J. Ayuk, Chairman of Africa Energy Chamber

Africa's chronic electricity shortages are colliding with a fast-growing digital economy—and that collision may offer a rare opportunity for power sector reform. According to *The State of African Energy: 2026 Outlook Report* by the African Energy Chamber (AEC), the expansion of data centre capacity across the continent could help modernise grids, attract investment and improve reliability if managed strategically.

Africa currently hosts just 223 data centres across 38 countries, a tiny share of the global total. South Africa leads with 56 facilities, followed by Kenya (19) and Nigeria (17). Yet growth is accelerating. The African data centre market, valued at about US\$3.49 billion in 2024, is projected to reach US\$6.81 billion by 2030, with electricity demand rising to roughly 2 GW.

Data centres are uniquely positioned to influence power markets because they require uninterrupted, high-quality electricity. In many African countries, unreliable grids force operators to rely on diesel generators, raising costs and emissions. Nigeria, for example, delivers only a few hours of grid power per day in many areas—untenable for facilities that must run continuously.

The AEC argues that this challenge could become a catalyst. The predictable, long-term demand of data centres makes them attractive anchor customers for new generation projects, grid upgrades and cleaner energy solutions. As operators invest in hybrid power systems—combining grid supply with solar, geothermal, gas and battery storage—they introduce modern grid technologies that can benefit wider electricity networks.

However, policy risks remain. African Energy Chamber chairman N.J. Ayuk warns that without strong frameworks, energy investments tied to digital infrastructure could serve only urban and commercial enclaves, deepening inequality. To avoid this, governments must integrate data-driven power investments into national electrification plans.

If aligned with reform, Africa's data centre boom could do more than power the cloud—it could help stabilise and modernise the continent's fragile electricity systems.

Africa's Currencies and Debt Strategies Diverge Amid Volatility



Libya's oil officials

A fresh round of currency moves across Africa is underscoring the uneven economic recovery confronting the continent's frontier and emerging markets. Libya's central bank this week devalued the dinar by 14.7% to 6.38 per dollar—its second adjustment in less than a year—highlighting how political fragmentation and oil revenue volatility continue to undermine macro stability in the oil-rich North African state. Officials cited falling crude prices, surging public spending and the absence of a unified national budget as key pressures.

In contrast, Angola is cautiously signaling macro stabilization. The Banco Nacional de Angola cut its benchmark rate by 100 basis points to 17.5% in January 2026—the largest easing since 2023—after inflation slowed to 15.7% in December. Authorities expect inflation to ease further to 13.5% by end-2026, supported by currency stability

and improved domestic supply conditions.

Angola is also leaning heavily on financial engineering to manage its debt profile. The government has extended a \$1 billion total return swap with JPMorgan from one year to three years and secured an additional \$500 million in financing at rates below 8%. While the deal has buoyed Angolan bond prices, it also illustrates the risks of such “off-screen” financing: a margin call earlier this year forced Luanda to post \$200 million in extra collateral

after bond prices fell. Similar unconventional funding strategies are increasingly being explored by low-rated issuers such as Senegal, Gabon and Cameroon.

Elsewhere, currency performance remains mixed. Nigeria's naira gained modestly at the official window, supported by central bank interventions, though a wide gap persists with the parallel market. Ghana's cedi, by contrast, continues to weaken amid strong corporate dollar demand and persistent FX backlogs, despite central bank dollar sales.

Taken together, the developments reflect a region navigating divergent paths: oil-dependent states grappling with fiscal and political fragility, reform-minded economies cautiously easing monetary policy, and several governments turning to complex financial structures to bridge funding gaps in a still-hostile global capital market.

Nigeria Clarifies Path for 2025 Oil Licensing Round

Nigeria has sharpened its pitch to global upstream investors as the Nigerian Upstream Petroleum Regulatory Commission (NUPRC) intensifies engagement ahead of the country's 2025 Licensing Round, offering 50 oil and gas blocks across frontier, onshore, shallow-water and deepwater terrains.

At a high-level investor webinar, the regulator laid out what it described as a decisive shift toward “regulation as a service,” aimed at reducing execution risk and restoring confidence in Africa's largest oil producer. The round is central to Nigeria's ambition to lift crude output to 2.7 million barrels per day by 2027, from about 1.5 million bpd today, while boosting reserves, revenues and foreign capital inflows.

NUPRC provided a step-by-step walkthrough of the licensing process, outlining pre-qualification criteria, bid timelines, evaluation methodology and the model contract governing the 2025 assets. Officials emphasized regulatory stability, transparency and predictability, underpinned by a fully digital bidding portal and independent oversight from NEITI, Nigeria's arm of the global Extractive Industries Transparency Initiative.

A key draw for investors is the sharp reduction in entry costs. Signature bonuses for the 2025 round have been cut to between \$3 million and \$7 million per block, down from \$10 million in 2024 and far below historical levels. The shift signals a move away from upfront cash extraction toward rewarding technical capability, credible work programmes, financial strength and rapid delivery to first production.

The webinar also addressed bankability concerns, with financial institutions stressing the importance of robust cash-flow projections, strong joint-venture governance and meaningful equity commitment by sponsors. Data access featured prominently, with multi-client seismic and well datasets available through the NUPRC portal and established providers, giving bidders tools to de-risk prospects.

NUPRC confirmed that successful bidders must post bid guarantees equivalent to 5% of the proposed signature bonus and meet post-award obligations within 90 days. Incentives for gas-focused developments, deepwater projects and cost-efficiency measures were also highlighted.

Major players, including Chevron and TotalEnergies, have already signalled interest—an early indication that Nigeria's recalibrated licensing strategy may be gaining traction.

Africa In A World Awash With Oil



Global oil markets are entering 2026 with an unusual combination of modest demand growth and abundant supply, a dynamic that carries mixed implications for Africa's producers. According to the IEA, global oil demand is forecast to rise by 930,000 barrels per day (bpd) in 2026, slightly above 2025 levels, driven entirely by non-OECD economies. Yet this incremental growth is being overwhelmed by supply expansion, with global output projected to increase by 2.5 million bpd this year, extending a surplus that has already pushed inventories sharply higher.

For Africa, this surplus-driven market is both a cushion and a constraint. On the one hand, benchmark crude prices remain around \$16 per barrel lower than a year ago, reflecting well-stocked markets and weakening pricing power. That environment limits fiscal upside for oil-dependent economies such as Nigeria,

Angola, Algeria and Gabon, where budget assumptions are often calibrated to higher prices. Refining margins, particularly for middle distillates, have also softened, further narrowing value capture across the barrel.

On the other hand, the current “buffer zone” of excess supply offers stability. Despite geopolitical disruptions in Iran, Venezuela, Russia and Kazakhstan, prices have remained contained, underscoring how deep inventories and non-OPEC+ growth have dampened volatility. For African producers, this stability reduces the risk of sudden price collapses but also weakens OPEC+ leverage, complicating coordinated supply management.

Africa's position within OPEC+ highlights the challenge. Several producers continue to underperform assigned targets due to capacity constraints and operational issues, leaving little spare capacity to monetise even if prices recover. At the same time, global supply growth is being led by the Americas and the Middle East, reinforcing Africa's marginal role in setting prices.

The implication is clear: in a market awash with oil, Africa's advantage will not come from volume alone. The focus is shifting toward cost discipline, operational reliability, gas monetisation, and downstream integration. In an era of plentiful supply and moderate demand growth, resilience—not scale—will define Africa's oil future.

Gold Set to Shatter \$6,000 Barrier in 2026

Gold is accelerating into historic territory in 2026, with leading banks and commodities strategists projecting prices could reach – and potentially exceed – \$6,000 per ounce. The metal's surge builds on a blistering 64% rally in 2025 and an already dramatic start to this year, with spot prices breaking decisively above \$5,300. What is driving this extraordinary ascent is not a single shock, but a powerful convergence of geopolitical risk, structural central-bank demand, and a deepening loss of confidence in traditional financial anchors.

Geopolitics remains the dominant catalyst. Heightened tensions involving the United States, NATO, Russia and Europe, renewed tariff threats, and persistent instability in Ukraine have entrenched a near-permanent risk-off mindset across global markets. Investors are increasingly pricing a world defined by fragmentation rather than cooperation, where alliances are fluid and economic policy is weaponised. In such an environment, gold's role as a neutral, apolitical store of value has regained primacy. Unlike currencies or sovereign bonds, bullion carries no counterparty risk—an attribute that is proving invaluable as trust in institutions erodes.

Monetary policy expectations are reinforcing the trend. Markets are increasingly convinced that the U.S. Federal Reserve will be forced into rate cuts as growth slows, debt servicing costs rise, and political pressure intensifies. Lower interest rates reduce the opportunity cost of holding a non-yielding asset, making gold more attractive relative to bonds and cash. At the same time, concerns about the Fed's long-term independence and the sustainability of U.S. fiscal policy have amplified demand for hard assets as hedges against currency debasement and policy missteps.

Perhaps the most powerful and underappreciated pillar of support is central-bank buying. Emerging-market institutions continue to diversify reserves away from the U.S. dollar, driven by sanctions risk, trade realignments and the increasing “weaponisation” of the global financial system. Analysts estimate monthly central-bank purchases could average around 60 tonnes in 2026, extending a trend that has already reshaped the gold market. This demand is largely price-insensitive and structural, providing a durable floor even during periods of volatility.

Investment flows further underline the strength of conviction. Gold-backed exchange-traded funds recorded an estimated \$89 billion of inflows in 2025—the highest since the pandemic-driven surge of 2020—while physical bar and coin demand remains robust across Asia and Europe despite record prices. Retail investors, wary of complex financial instruments and volatile equity markets, are increasingly drawn to gold's simplicity as a hedge against systemic uncertainty.

Corrections remain possible. A sharp easing of geopolitical tensions, a hawkish repricing of U.S. rates, or sudden liquidity shocks could trigger pullbacks. Yet most analysts view any declines as temporary within a broader secular bull market. As Bank of America strategist Michael Widmer has observed, rallies typically end when their drivers fade—and today's drivers show little sign of dissipating.

Looking ahead, \$6,000 no longer appears speculative. It represents a logical repricing of risk, trust and stability in an increasingly uncertain global order. For both near-term traders and long-term allocators, gold's message is clear: uncertainty is no longer episodic—it is structural.



• Gold prices have gone through the roof

Tanzania Expands Mining Ties with India, Korea

Tanzania is strengthening its mining sector through strategic partnerships with India and Korea. Minister for Minerals Anthony Mavunde met Ambassadors Bishwadi Dey and Eunju Ahn in Dodoma to discuss capacity building, investment promotion, and geological research collaboration.

India offered training programs and scholarships to enhance Tanzanian expertise and explored investment in mineral value-added industries. With Korea, discussions focused on advancing the Mahenge Graphite Project and fostering cooperation between the Korea Institute of Geoscience and Mineral Resources and the Geological Survey of Tanzania. These initiatives aim to boost technical skills, efficiency, and sustainable growth in Tanzania's mining industry.

High-Grade Gold Emerges at Enchi

By Our Reporter

Newcore Gold's latest diamond drilling results from the Boin Gold Deposit at its 100%-owned Enchi Project in Ghana mark a technical and strategic inflection point for the company, underscoring the depth potential of a district-scale gold system that remains materially underexplored.

The standout intercept—147.5 g/t gold over 1 metre in hole KBDD100—represents the first instance of visible gold encountered by drilling at Enchi. While narrow, the significance lies less in width than in geological validation. The intercept confirms the presence of high-grade shoots persisting well into fresh rock, at vertical depths approaching 300 metres, far below the historical average drilling depth of roughly 100 metres at Boin. This materially strengthens Newcore's geological model and supports the thesis that Enchi's resource base can grow both in grade and scale with depth.

Equally important is continuity. All six diamond drill holes reported intersected gold mineralization, with multiple broad



• Officials of Canadian firm Newcore Gold

intervals grading above 1 g/t gold, including 3.22 g/t over 17 metres and 1.70 g/t over 25.5 metres in KBDD102. These results demonstrate lateral and down-dip continuity across three high-grade shoots extending over a 1.5-kilometre strike length, reinforcing confidence in the structural controls

underpinning mineralization.

From a development perspective, the timing is critical. Newcore is advancing Enchi toward a Pre-Feasibility Study targeted for completion in the first half of 2026. The current drilling phase—part of a 45,000-metre program—serves a dual purpose: upgrading near-surface resources through infill drilling while simultaneously testing the upside potential at depth. The latter now appears increasingly compelling.

With nearly one million ounces already defined across Enchi and more than half of the Boin soil anomaly still untested, the emergence of high-grade mineralization in deeper fresh rock elevates Enchi from a conventional open-pit development story to one with credible longer-term optionality. For investors tracking West African gold projects, Newcore's latest results suggest Enchi's best chapters may still lie beneath the surface.

Ghana's Gold Reforms: Fair Value or Risk?

Ghana's renewed push to extract greater value from its gold sector is both politically inevitable and economically fraught. As bullion prices surge to historic highs—hovering near \$5,000 an ounce—the state is under intense pressure to demonstrate that Africa's top gold producer is not merely exporting wealth, but capturing it.

At the heart of the debate are proposed reforms that would scrap long-standing mining stability agreements, sharply raise royalties through a sliding scale of up to 12%, tighten licence terms and impose tougher local-content and community-development obligations. Government officials argue these measures are pragmatic corrections to a system that has been abused. Major miners warn they risk choking investment, jobs and future output.

Both claims carry weight.

Why Ghana Is Acting Now

Ghana pioneered stability agreements in the early 2000s, locking in tax and royalty terms for up to 15 years in exchange for large, capital-intensive mine investments. The model worked—spectacularly so. Billions of dollars flowed in, helping Ghana overtake South Africa as the continent's largest gold producer.

But success has exposed structural flaws. Stability agreements tied to gross revenue rather than profit have coincided with complaints that multinationals have reinvested Ghanaian earnings elsewhere, underpaid local obligations and delivered limited visible benefits to host communities. For a country grappling with fiscal stress and social discontent, the optics are increasingly untenable.

The government's argument is straightforward: when gold prices quadruple, the state's share should not remain frozen.

Sliding royalties, shorter licences and direct revenue-sharing with communities are meant to restore legitimacy to the mining compact.

The Investment Risk Is Real

Yet the Chamber of Mines' warning is not idle scaremongering. Ghana's miners already face one of the heaviest fiscal burdens globally: royalties of 3–5%, a 3% sustainability levy, 35% corporate tax, dividend taxes and a 10% free carried state interest—all levied largely on gross revenue. Pushing royalties toward 9–12% risks moving Ghana decisively up the global effective tax curve.

Mining is a long-cycle business. Capital does not flee overnight—but it does quietly reroute. Marginal projects are shelved, expansions delayed, and exploration budgets trimmed. Over time, that translates into lower output, fewer jobs and declining fiscal receipts—the opposite of what reforms intend.

The experience of Mali offers a cautionary parallel. Aggressive renegotiations and the scrapping of stability clauses have delivered short-term revenue clawbacks, but at the cost of operational disruptions, legal battles and a sharp drop in output. Ghana, to its credit, has explicitly ruled out retroactive application—an important signal to investors.

Indigenous Players: Necessary, but Not Sufficient

Would Ghana benefit from more indigenous players? Almost certainly—but not automatically.

Expanding medium-scale licences and strengthening local participation could anchor more value domestically, deepen supply chains and reduce capital flight. However, large-scale gold mining remains technologically complex and capital-intensive. Indigenous participation works best through structured partnerships, financing support, skills transfer and equity participation—



• The gold boom is fueling environmental crisis in Africa, particularly in Ghana

not by displacing experienced operators wholesale.

Without access to long-term capital, geological data and risk-tolerant financing, indigenisation risks becoming symbolic rather than transformative.

A Narrow Path Forward

Ghana's reforms are justified in intent but perilous in execution. The state is right to demand more during a price supercycle—and to end the automatic renewal of agreements that no longer reflect economic reality. But predictability remains the industry's red line.

If Ghana calibrates its sliding royalty formula carefully, limits stability protections to genuine capital recovery periods, and enforces rules consistently rather than punitively, it could emerge stronger: higher revenues, fewer abuses, and greater domestic participation.

If it overshoots, capital will not protest—it will simply look elsewhere.

For Africa's gold powerhouse, the challenge is not whether to reform, but how precisely to get the balance right.

Uganda's Golden Leap: From Coffee to Bullion Powerhouse

Uganda's export landscape has undergone a seismic shift. In 2025, gold shipments leapt 75.8% year-on-year, reaching \$5.8 billion—surpassing coffee as the East African nation's leading source of foreign exchange. According to Adam Mugume, executive director for research and economic analysis at the Bank of Uganda, soaring international gold prices played a central role, incentivizing a wave of new traders and dealers into the sector.

But the story behind the numbers is more complex. Uganda produces relatively little gold domestically. Instead, it has become a regional processing and trading hub, handling bullion from neighbouring Democratic Republic of Congo, South Sudan, and beyond. The country's strategic positioning, combined with a rising appetite for safe-haven assets amid geopolitical uncertainty, has transformed Uganda into an unexpected gold corridor for East Africa.

The surge has also been fuelled by domestic developments. In 2025, Uganda inaugurated



• High prices means intensified search for precious metals

its first large-scale mine—a \$250 million Chinese-owned operation in the east—signalling a new era of industrial mining. Though still in its infancy, this project demonstrates that Uganda is not only a conduit for regional gold but is beginning to build its own production capacity.

Globally, gold prices jumped over 64% last year, reflecting investor fears tied to geopolitical tension, supply-chain disruptions, and inflationary pressures. For

Uganda, this windfall translated into record exports, even without reporting exact volumes. The inflow of dealers and the formalization of gold trading have also broadened government oversight, raising questions about regulation, taxation, and the potential for long-term sustainable growth.

Yet challenges remain. Uganda's role as a regional processing hub exposes it to fluctuations in cross-border supply, illicit trade risks, and dependence on global prices. Scaling domestic production, enforcing transparency, and balancing foreign investment with local economic benefits will be key to ensuring the gold boom translates into lasting national wealth.

Uganda's ascent from a coffee-dependent economy to a regional gold powerhouse is meteoric—but whether it can sustain this golden momentum depends on careful policy, investment in mining infrastructure, and a commitment to turning transient surges into durable prosperity.

Cote d'Ivoire – Ghana Maritime Boundary Dispute – The Negotiations

The Negotiation Phase

The negotiation process itself has to be looked at in two distinct phases; one from April 2010 to April 2011 in which Ghana was effectively driving Cote d'Ivoire into submission, and that from April 2012 to December 2014 with Ghana on the retreat, following wrongful political and technical decisions.

Negotiation Phase I – 2010-2011

The first phase of the maritime boundary negotiations actually started in Accra from 27-28 April 2010, true to the resolve of the parties and in keeping with our agreement to resume negotiations after the lodgment of our respective submissions for the establishment of the continental shelf beyond 200 nautical miles. This was the first time the parties articulated their substantive positions and deliberated on them. The outcome was a major boost to a negotiated settlement, as the parties converged on a number of issues. The Ghana team was led by the Minister for Foreign Affairs and Regional Integration, Alhaji Muhammed Mumuni, while the Ivorianians were led by their Minister of the Interior and Chief of Staff, the late Désiré Asségnini Tagro.



Fig. 2: Cote d'Ivoire's 2nd Position through Communication dated May 31, 2010

to a long break in negotiations, as attention shifted to political issues which finally brought President Alassane Ouattara to the throne of the Republic of Cote d'Ivoire in December 2010.

During the technical session, the Ghana Team reiterated the position that the existing line used by the national oil companies, GNPC of Ghana and PETROCI of Cote d'Ivoire, be formalized as the maritime boundary between the two States. Ghana's stance was based on the fact that the position of the line generally approximates any outcome of the fast accepting

a cut-off effect on Ivorian maritime space.

The significant milestone achieved at this meeting, however, was the fact that the parties agreed to recognize the Land Boundary Terminus Pillar (BP55), as an inheritance from the colonial rule in line with the principle of uti possidetis juris and to jointly re-survey it to ascertain more accurately the coordinates, in view of the advancement of technology and the evolution of more precise measuring instruments. The Parties also agreed to conduct all maritime boundary discussions within the framework of international law and make use of the Law of the Sea Convention and the Handbook on the Delimitation of Maritime Boundaries, prepared by the Division for Ocean Affairs and the Law of the Sea (DOALOS).

Unfortunately, Cote d'Ivoire, in a written communication entitled "THE FIFTH REUNION", dated May 31, 2010, varied its position to yet another meridian, but this time round, through BP55 (Fig. 2).

The Ghana Boundary Commission's response to this new meridian remained the same as proposed by the technical team earlier, with emphasis on the strong legal support of the equidistance method in contemporary maritime delimitation politics as reflected in the decisions of the International Court Justice (ICJ) and Arbitral

Tribunals. Ghana further argued that, in view of the relatively smooth coastlines of Ghana and Côte d'Ivoire, in the area to be delimited, the equidistance method creates the most equitable result between the two States and observed no circumstances that warranted the rejection or even modification of the equidistance line. Citing case law, Ghana drew attention to the fact that even where relevant circumstances exist, the equidistance method is not abandoned but modified. Further urging Cote d'Ivoire to accept the customary line, Ghana expressed how this line is much more favourable to Cote d'Ivoire stating thus:

"This line is a modified form of equidistance and is even disadvantageous to Ghana; it results in a reduced maritime space for Ghana in favour of Côte d'Ivoire. If Strict Equidistance were to be applied the resulting line would have deflected more to the west of Ghana."

This was something worth considering but instead, the Government of Cote d'Ivoire came up with a more preposterous claim of a bisector line that will incline to the east and create a wedge with the existing line.

Worse still, Cote d'Ivoire, in September 2011, issued a communiqué to oil companies with interest on both sides of the existing line, to stop work on the Ghana side, now seen as belonging to Cote d'Ivoire. They also called on Ghana to stop all economic activities on the Ghana side of the line, claiming Ghana's exploration activities in the area were unilateral.

By November same year, when the parties reconvened in Accra, the Ivorian Government had followed up their threat by setting up five new blocks (Fig. 3) in the premeditated overlap region for promotion to international oil companies. After this, the process went dead silent till 2013 due to the political turbulence in Cote d'Ivoire during this period.

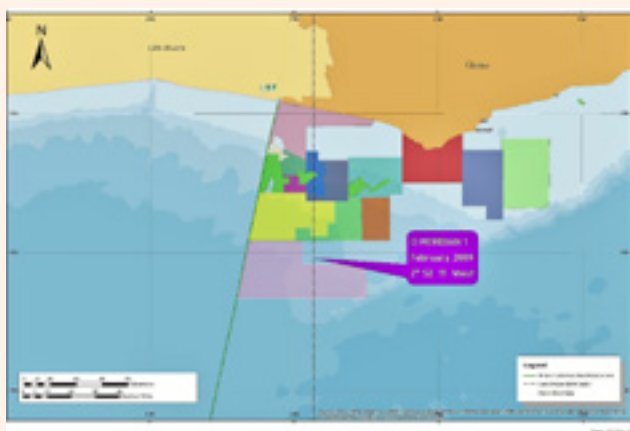


Fig. 1: Meridian 1 - Cote d'Ivoire proposed delimitation line in February 2009

Désiré Tagro deserves special mention in this meeting as he showed statesmanship and full commitment to a negotiated settlement; he is credited with the initial breakthrough in these negotiations. In his opening statement, Désiré Tagro bluntly stated that the issue in respect of which the Ivorian delegation was in Ghana concerns the delimitation of the maritime boundary and that the exercise was not about oil and gas. He therefore appealed to the media to state the matter accurately in their reportage to avoid stirring up passions, recalling that the land boundaries were agreed upon by our predecessors without any fuss; there was thus no reason why the maritime delimitation should be hyped. Désiré unfortunately lost his life in the grueling civil war that engulfed that country and led

3-step approach to maritime delimitation, which normally starts with a provisional equidistance line. Ghana further noted that, giving the fact that the line has been used by both States for decades, the legal principle of acquiescence may apply. However, Ghana was malleable to drawing a completely new line based on the equidistance as the starting point.

Cote d'Ivoire, who had in 2009 proposed Meridian 2° 52' 11" W (Fig.1) and proposed a formal calendar for negotiations with a view to signing an agreement within a timeframe of not more than twelve (12) months, now requested for time to study Ghana's proposal again, arguing that the equidistance methodology inherent in the 3-Step Approach, deflects the line westwards with the potential of

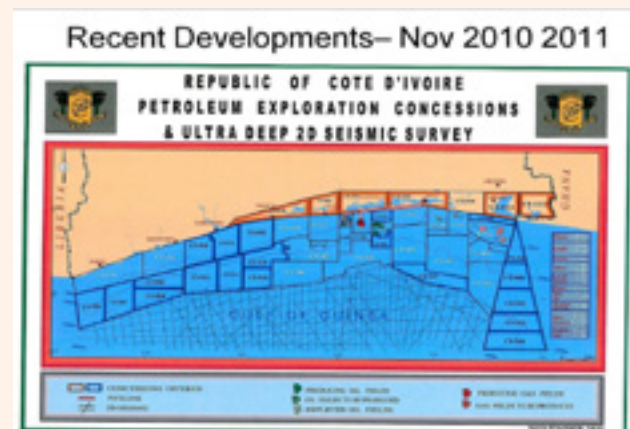


Fig.3: Cote d'Ivoire Promotional Map showing blocks C1-540 to C1-544 in the forged overlap area shown in blue triangle.

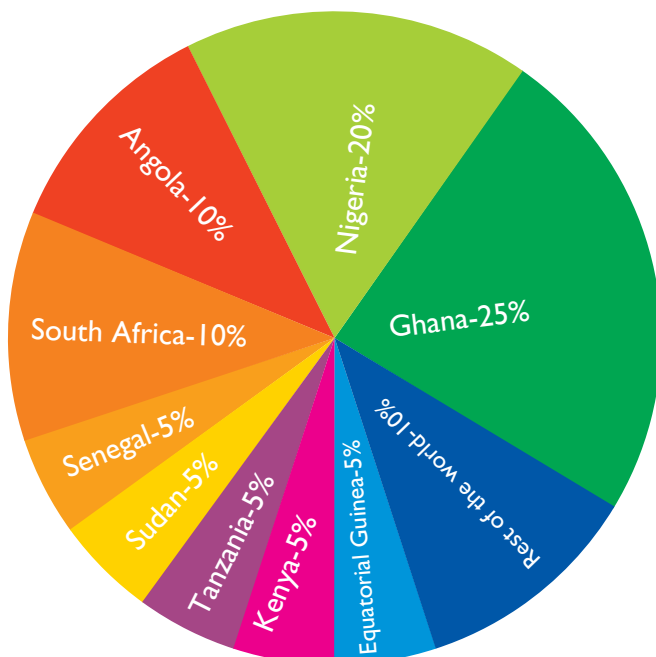
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